

# MASTERING QUESTION 2

Writer's Effect • 9 marks • R4

*Exact past-paper wording • Complete official extracts • Examiner-led methods*

## LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this worksheet, you should be able to recognise every major Q2 task, move beyond literal comprehension, explain connotations and images in context, and construct a precise 3-mark example-explanation response.

## What does Question 2 test?

### OFFICIAL OBJECTIVE

R4: demonstrate understanding of how writers achieve effects and influence readers.

### THE GOLDEN DIFFERENCE

Q1 asks WHAT the text means. Q2 asks HOW the writer's language shapes the reader's impression.

## The six recurring Q2 tasks

- **impressions from an extract:** state the pictures, atmosphere or qualities created.
- **effect of a phrase or image:** unpack its associations and contextual impact.
- **precise word choice:** explain why the chosen verb/adjective is stronger than a neutral alternative.
- **suggestion or foreshadowing:** infer what the writer prepares the reader to expect.
- **character feeling or attitude:** infer the feeling conveyed by tone and wording.
- **select an example and explain:** quote precisely, then zoom in on its connotations.

### SIR RUFUS TIP

Do not memorise part letters. In November 2025, Variant 11 used 2–2–1–1–3 marks, while Variant 12 used 1–2–1–2–3. Recognise the command and the mark value.

# PART A — Impressions from an Extract

## 1. Two impressions

### READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“It’s late but this southern sun is still burning in a flame red sky. The terrain is flatter here too with dry, brown, trampled grass.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, Q2(a), lines 61–62

**What two impressions does the writer want to convey to the reader in this extract?**

**[2]**  
**R4**

### HOW TO ANSWER

Read the whole extract. Find two DIFFERENT impression zones. Here, one can come from the sun/sky and one from the terrain/grass. State each impression in your own words; do not merely copy an adjective.

### MODEL ANSWER

The sun is fiercely hot and makes the sky appear to be on fire. The land seems parched, barren and damaged by heavy trampling.

Marks: one developed impression from each zone = 2

### COMMON TRAP

“The sky is red and the grass is brown” only repeats surface details. It does not explain the atmosphere or picture created.

### SIR RUFUS TIP

Two marks usually require two separate effects—not two synonyms for the same idea.

## Literal detail → developed impression

| Literal wording         | Effective impression                |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| “burning” / “flame red” | fierce heat; the sky seems ablaze   |
| “dry, brown”            | parched, lifeless, barren landscape |
| “trampled”              | damaged and worn by many feet       |

## PART B — Effect of an Image or Phrase

### 2. Unpack a simile

#### READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“At the edges, near the track, canvas tents have popped up like mushrooms.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, Q2(b), lines 62–63

What effect does the writer suggest about the tents by using the phrase “popped up like mushrooms” to describe them?

[2]  
R4

#### HOW TO ANSWER

Use IMAGE → ASSOCIATIONS → CONTEXT. Mushrooms appear rapidly, unexpectedly, in groups and in many places. Transfer two suitable associations to the tents.

#### MODEL ANSWER

The tents seem to have appeared suddenly, almost from nowhere, and there are many of them clustered closely together.

Marks: sudden appearance = 1; large number/cluster = 1

#### COMMON TRAP

“It is a simile” earns nothing by itself. Naming the technique is not explaining its effect.

#### SIR RUFUS TIP

For a comparison, ask: What qualities connect the two things? Only use associations that fit this context.

### 3. A single word can carry two effects

#### READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“Ice crystals cracked and crunched against my teeth, dissolving on my tongue with a sparkling sensation.”

Source: 1123/12/M/J/2024, Q2(a), lines 38–39; discussed in the June 2024 Examiner Report

What effect does the writer suggest about the sensation of the crystals dissolving on his tongue by using the word “sparkling” to describe it?

[2]  
R4

#### HOW TO ANSWER

Focus only on “sparkling”. Think of physical sensation and emotional response: a lively tingling or fizzing feeling, and something pleasurable, surprising or magical.

**MODEL ANSWER**

The crystals create a lively tingling or fizzing sensation, making the unfamiliar experience feel pleasurable and almost magical.

Marks: physical sensation = 1; pleasure/wonder = 1

**COMMON TRAP**

Coldness and melting are narrative facts. “Stinging” suggests pain, which conflicts with the enjoyable context.

## PART C — Precise Word Choice

### 4. Why this word rather than a neutral word?

**READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT**

“I peer inside through a small hole in the canvas.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, Q2(c), line 65

**Explain why the writer uses the word “peer” rather than “look” in this sentence.**

**[1]  
R4**

**HOW TO ANSWER**

Compare meanings. “Look” is neutral. “Peer” suggests close, careful or strained looking because seeing is difficult.

**MODEL ANSWER**

“Peer” shows that Jacob must look closely and strain to see through the small hole.

Marks: precise contextual difference = 1

**COMMON TRAP**

Do not answer only “peer is more effective”. State exactly what extra meaning it carries.

### 5. A forceful verb

**READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT**

“It had been lifted from its concrete blocks and tossed onto its side.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, Q2(c), line 47

**Explain why the writer uses the word “lifted” rather than “moved” in this expression.**

**[1]  
R4**

**HOW TO ANSWER**

Identify the direction and force. “Lifted” means raised upwards, suggesting that the wind was powerful enough to make a heavy structure seem easy to move.

**MODEL ANSWER**

“Lifted” shows an upward movement and emphasises the extraordinary power of the wind.

Marks: upward movement or force/ease = 1

**SIR RUFUS TIP**

Use the substitution test: replace the chosen word with the neutral alternative, then explain what vivid meaning disappears.

## PART D — Suggestion, Foreshadowing and Attitude

### 6. Foreshadow what happens next

**READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT**

“Later that month, I was nearly proved wrong.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, Q2(a), line 41

What does the writer want to suggest to us about what is going to happen next?

[1]  
R4

**HOW TO ANSWER**

Look backwards to the belief being challenged, then predict the coming event. The sentence prepares us for Odin to leave, disappear, escape or become lost.

**MODEL ANSWER**

The writer prepares us for Odin to leave or disappear, although not quite permanently.

Marks: valid anticipation = 1

**COMMON TRAP**

“Something bad will happen” is too vague. Foreshadowing answers must identify the likely development.

## 7. Feeling revealed by tone

### READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“‘Listen,’ says Camel softly. ‘If you got a life to go back to, I reckon that’s what you should do.’”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, Q2(d), line 76

What does the writer want to suggest to the reader about Camel’s feelings towards Jacob at this point in the story?

[1]  
R4

### HOW TO ANSWER

Zoom in on “softly” and the advice. Infer the attitude behind them: affection, compassion, concern or a wish to protect Jacob’s interests.

### MODEL ANSWER

Camel feels affection and concern for Jacob and wants what is best for him.

Marks: valid feeling/attitude = 1

### COMMON TRAP

“He tells Jacob to go home” retells the dialogue. It does not identify Camel’s feeling.

## PART E — Explain the Effect of a Key Word

### 8. A two-mark adjective question

### READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“Julie and I had already made a brave start on rebuilding the sheds, mournfully avoiding the remains of the cage.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, Q2(d), lines 50–51

What effect does the writer suggest by using the word “brave” to describe Julie and Rex’s start on rebuilding the sheds?

[2]  
R4

### HOW TO ANSWER

Stay on the named word. “Brave” suggests both the difficulty of the task and their positive response to it. Give two connected but distinct effects.

**MODEL ANSWER**

Rebuilding is a difficult and emotionally painful task, but they show courage and determination by beginning it instead of giving up.

Marks: difficulty = 1; courage/determination/optimism = 1

**COMMON TRAP**

The mark scheme warns that the focus is “brave”, not “mournfully avoiding”. Do not analyse the wrong words.

**SIR RUFUS TIP**

Underline the exact focus word in the question. A good analysis of the wrong phrase cannot earn the mark.

## A reliable response frame

**WORD → MEANING → IMPRESSION**

The word “\_\_\_\_\_” suggests \_\_\_\_\_ because it is associated with \_\_\_\_\_. This makes the reader see/feel/imagine \_\_\_\_\_.

**USE FLEXIBLY**

The frame is a thinking scaffold, not a sentence to memorise. For a one-mark answer, one precise effect is enough. For two marks, develop two distinct effects.

## PART F — The 3-Mark Example + Explanation Task

### 9. Select and analyse one example

**READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT**

“Brilliantly painted red and gold cages, their sides propped open to reveal lions and tigers, hypnotise the captive audience. Llamas and zebras bring wild whoops of delight. The big top is packed solid, glowing and pulsing with the sound of the audience laughing, clapping and whistling. Sometimes there’s a collective intake of breath or ripple of nervous squeals as a trapeze flies by. The elephant looms against the far sidewall, an enormous beast the colour of storm clouds. She’s gargantuan. Her skin is mottled and cracked like a scorched riverbed. She trots forwards and the crowd erupts with glee.”

Source: 1123/11/O/N/2025, Q2(e), lines 69–75

**Identify one example from the text above of how the writer uses language effectively to convey the reactions of the audience in the big top. Explain the impression the writer creates in the example you have identified.**

**[3]  
R4**

**HOW TO ANSWER**

1 mark: copy one complete, relevant example exactly. 2 marks: zoom in on its words/image and explain two valid associations or one fully developed impression. Analyse only the example you selected.

**MODEL ANSWER**

Example: “the crowd erupts with glee”

Explanation: “erupts” makes the reaction seem sudden, explosive and uncontrollable, while “glee” conveys the crowd’s intense happiness and excitement.

Marks: accurate example = 1; two developed effects = 2

**COMMON TRAP**

Do not use ellipses, line references or an incomplete fragment. Do not select one quotation and explain a different one.

**SIR RUFUS TIP**

The examiner report says to zoom in on individual words, explain associations in context and avoid merely repeating the quotation.

## How the 3 Marks Are Built

### Example 1: “a collective intake of breath”

| Response                                                                                                                                                         | Likely mark | Why                                                    |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| It is effective.                                                                                                                                                 | 0/3         | No quoted example and no effect.                       |
| “a collective intake of breath” shows they gasp.                                                                                                                 | 2/3         | Valid example + one straightforward effect.            |
| “a collective intake of breath” suggests the whole audience gasps as one, momentarily holding its breath in shared astonishment and fear for the trapeze artist. | 3/3         | Precise example + togetherness + astonishment/tension. |

### Example 2: “ripple of nervous squeals”

**MODEL ANSWER**

The image of a “ripple” suggests a small wave of high-pitched sound spreading through the crowd. “Nervous squeals” convey shared fear and tension for the trapeze artist’s safety.

### Do / Do not

- **DO:** quote the full relevant example.



- **DO:** explain connotations, pictures, sounds or feelings.
- **DO:** connect every comment to the specific context.
- **DO NOT:** award yourself a mark for naming “simile”, “metaphor” or “personification”.
- **DO NOT:** write a general comment that could fit any quotation.
- **DO NOT:** analyse extra words outside your selected example.

### EXAMINER-REPORT PRINCIPLE

Terminology is optional. Understanding the effect is essential. “It is a metaphor” earns no credit unless the response explains how the image works.

## YOUR TURN — Official Mixed Practice A

### INSTRUCTIONS

Answer the four official questions below before checking the key. Underline the exact focus word or phrase. Match the number of distinct ideas to the marks.

### Practice A

#### READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“We’d expected the worst, but the scene at dawn was a picture of carnage, like an army of giants had wreaked havoc outside: most of the trees in the area had been blown over, the whole world seemed torn apart, unfriendly and unfamiliar.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, Q2(b), lines 44–46

What two impressions does the writer want to convey to the reader about the storm in this sentence?

[2]  
R4

### Practice B

#### READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“It had been lifted from its concrete blocks and tossed onto its side.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, Q2(c), line 47

Explain why the writer uses the word “lifted” rather than “moved” in this expression.

[1]  
R4

## Practice C

## READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“Julie and I had already made a brave start on rebuilding the sheds, mournfully avoiding the remains of the cage.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, Q2(d), lines 50–51

What effect does the writer suggest by using the word “brave” to describe Julie and Rex’s start on rebuilding the sheds?

[2]

R4

## YOUR TURN — Official Mixed Practice B

## Practice D: 3-mark selection and analysis

## READ THE OFFICIAL EXTRACT

“Weak cheeping revealed the smallest shadow of a bedraggled Odin perched precariously at the top of the tallest tree and shivering violently. Seriously shaken by his experience, he wasn’t in a trusting mood. At the risk of appearing a complete idiot, I called up in a hopefully endearing voice, ‘Odin, come to Daddy.’ The bird’s response was immediate. With a croak of relief he dropped from the tree like a bundle of black rags, landing at my feet. Normally he hated being picked up, but on this occasion our indestructible raven was more than willing to be scooped into my arms and taken home.”

Source: 1123/12/O/N/2025, Q2(e), lines 58–64

Identify one example from the text above of how the writer uses language effectively to describe Odin. Explain the impression the writer creates in the example you have identified.

[3]

R4

## PLAN FIRST

Example (copy exactly): \_\_\_\_\_

Key word/image: \_\_\_\_\_ Associations: \_\_\_\_\_

Contextual impression: \_\_\_\_\_

**SIR RUFUS TIP**

Choose a rich example such as “the smallest shadow of a bedraggled Odin”, “perched precariously”, “like a bundle of black rags” or “our indestructible raven”. Then analyse only the chosen words.

# ANSWER KEY AND FINAL CHECK

## Official mixed-practice answers

### MODEL ANSWER

A. The storm has caused catastrophic destruction, making the scene resemble a battlefield. Its enormous, almost monstrous force has made the landscape seem hostile and unrecognisable. [2]

B. “Lifted” shows that the shed was raised upwards and emphasises the extraordinary force of the wind. [1]

C. Beginning the repair is difficult and emotionally painful, but they show courage and determination instead of giving up. [2]

D. One possible answer—Example: “like a bundle of black rags”. Explanation: Odin appears limp, dishevelled and powerless as he falls; the image makes him seem physically battered and pitiful rather than like his normally lively, indestructible self. [3]

## Final Q2 checklist

- I identified whether the question asks for an impression, effect or suggestion.
- I underlined the exact focus word or phrase.
- I gave as many distinct ideas as there are marks.
- I moved beyond literal events and explained associations or implications.
- I used my own words to explain effect.
- I did not rely on naming a language technique.
- For Q2(e), I copied one complete relevant example exactly.
- I analysed only the example I selected.
- I connected every effect to the context.
- I stopped once I had earned the available marks.



### SIR RUFUS' FINAL ADVICE

**Do not translate the quotation. Explore it. Zoom in, unpack the associations, connect them to the context, and write only what earns the marks.**